

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Rashid Khan

Address: 9 Bicknoller Close Sutton SM2 5NQ

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am writing as a nearby and local resident of SM2 5NQ, a postcode in very close proximity to the application site, to express my wholehearted and unreserved support for the proposed Belmont and Sutton Muslim Assembly (BASMA) community facility at the former Sutton Ambulance Station on Dorset Road, Sutton.

I am a local resident with deep roots in this community. My wife works locally in the SM2 area, and our children attend Avenue Primary School and Harris Academy, both within this community. Our household is entirely embedded in and dependent upon the health, cohesion and vibrancy of this local community. It is from this perspective, as a parent, a neighbour, and a local stakeholder, that I offer this letter of support.

From reading the Transport Statement and Travel Plan, I am reassured that traffic and parking have been carefully considered. The proposal provides 14 onsite car spaces (including disabled and EV bays) and secure cycle parking, and commits to marshalled onsite parking management and promotion of walking, carsharing and public transport. Surveys show that most existing BASMA users already walk, with over half of Friday attendees arriving on foot and only a minority driving. Parking beat surveys in nearby streets recorded daytime utilisation at under 50%, even on Fridays, indicating spare capacity and that overspill parking is unlikely to be severe.

As a parent, schoolrun safety is paramount to me. I welcome the clear commitment to stagger Friday prayer times so they do not clash with Avenue dropoff and pickup, and to use stewards to supervise vehicle movements during the busiest periods, so Dorset Road will not be affected. The hailandride S2 and S4 bus services and the short walk from Belmont Station also mean many

visitors can come without a car, consistent with Sutton Local Plan Policies 35-37 on sustainable travel and appropriate parking.

The proposal reuses an existing brownfield public service site with a modest extension, improved landscaping, cycle parking and onsite car parking. Technical reports show that most existing users already walk, that parking stress on surrounding streets is well below capacity, and that staggered Friday prayer times and marshalled onsite parking will avoid conflict with school dropoff and pickup. Noise assessment work demonstrates that activities inside a wellinsulated, singlestorey building will remain below existing background levels and will be quieter than the former 24hour ambulance use.

Safe Spaces and Youth Programmes:

As a father of my children growing up in Sutton, I am acutely aware of the lack of structured, safe, after-school spaces for young people in our area. The proposed BASMA facility would provide exactly the kind of safe, supervised, and nurturing environment that young people need, particularly in the SM2/Belmont corridor where provision is limited. Youth programmes delivered through community facilities of this kind have a well-evidenced impact on diverting young people from anti-social behaviour, building confidence, and fostering a sense of belonging. My children, along with their classmates from Avenue and Harris, would directly benefit from having structured youth activities within walking distance of home and school.

Education and Structured Learning:

The facility proposes to operate under Use Class F1 (Learning and Non-Residential Institutions), which reflects BASMA's explicit commitment to education. not only religious education, but wider social learning, literacy, and life skills programming. As a parent who cares deeply about my children's educational enrichment beyond the school day, I strongly welcome a community resource that provides structured educational activities in a local, accessible and trusted setting. Educational community centres of this kind form part of the wider educational ecosystem that complements schools like Avenue and Harris Academy.

Wellbeing, Women's Support and Elderly Engagement:

My wife, who works locally, is one of many women in our community who would benefit from the wellbeing and support networks that BASMA intends to provide. Women's support initiatives, health and wellbeing sessions, and informal peer networks are genuinely life-changing for residents who may be isolated, working long hours, or managing caring responsibilities. Similarly, our community has a significant elderly population who would benefit enormously from regular, accessible engagement activities, reducing loneliness and social isolation in a borough where these are recognised public health challenges.

Inter-Community Interaction and Social Cohesion:

I wish to specifically address the concerns raised by some local residents about this facility creating division. I believe strongly that the opposite is true. Community facilities run by well-established charities like BASMA, which has operated Friday prayers at St John's Community Hall on Northdown Road for several years with no adverse impact whatsoever on neighbours, serve as bridges between communities, not barriers. A permanent, well-designed, purpose-fit facility enables BASMA to open its doors to the wider community for inter-faith dialogue, shared events, and cross-community partnerships. A formal facility is far more capable of hosting such inter-community interaction than a temporary hired hall.

3 halls are proposed - 1 for ladies, 1 for prayers and 1 for multi-use which is for all communities. There will be a publicly available defibrillator which is a vital life saving device.

Addressing Loneliness and Isolation:

The borough's own public health data recognises loneliness and isolation as significant challenges in Sutton. Community facilities that provide structured activities, social clubs, hobby groups, support circles, classes, are among the most cost-effective public health interventions. The proposed BASMA centre, with its range of planned social programmes, directly addresses this. The repurposing of a vacant former ambulance station into an active community hub is exactly the type of development the Sutton Local Plan's social infrastructure policies are designed to encourage and protect.

Planning Merits:

From a planning perspective, I note that the proposal is for a change of use and refurbishment, not new build. The existing structure is already well-established on Dorset Road. The comprehensive suite of supporting documents submitted, including a Transport Statement, Parking Survey, Noise Assessment, Fire Strategy, and Biodiversity Net Gain Assessment, demonstrates the thoroughness and professionalism of this application. I urge the Planning Authority to give full weight to these technical submissions when assessing the application.

I respectfully urge the Planning Authority to grant planning permission for this application. This facility will make a genuine, lasting, positive difference to the lives of residents like me, my family, and our neighbours in SM2 and across the Sutton Borough.

Yours faithfully,

Rashid Khan